

Why 40/40/20 — the weighting and what it claims

The argument for putting forty per cent of a controls credential on finance and twenty per cent on AI

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PROJECT CONTROLS INSTITUTE GLOBAL, INC.
AI proposes. The professional disposes.

— Summary

A certification weighting is an argument about a job, not an allocation of pages. This document sets out why the PCL-AI puts forty per cent of the examination on project accounting and finance, forty per cent on project management principles and twenty per cent on AI — with a worked example showing how a controls professional's forecast decision moves reported revenue — and states plainly what evidence would change the weighting.

— About this document

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Contents

1. What a weighting is a claim about.....	4
2. Why finance is forty per cent.....	4
3. Worked example — one forecast decision, two revenue numbers.....	5
4. Why project management is forty per cent and not sixty	5
5. Why AI is twenty per cent, and not a chapter.....	6
6. Why the weights attach to groups and not to domains	6
7. What would change the weighting.....	6
8. How this goes wrong	7
Related	7
Sources and standards.....	7
Status and version	8

Why 40/40/20 — the weighting and what it claims

In one paragraph. A certification weighting is an argument about a job, not an allocation of pages. This document sets out why the PCL-AI puts forty per cent of the examination on project accounting and finance, forty per cent on project management principles and twenty per cent on AI — with a worked example showing how a controls professional's forecast decision moves reported revenue — and states plainly what evidence would change the weighting.

Who this is for. Practitioners deciding whether the framework describes their job, heads of controls functions judging whether it describes their team's, and anyone who thought the finance share too high or the AI share too low.

— 1. What a weighting is a claim about

Three groups carry the framework: project accounting and finance at forty per cent, project management principles at forty per cent, AI knowledge and practical approach at twenty. The domains inside each are mapped in [PCB-02 – The thirteen domains at a glance](#).

Those three numbers are the most consequential editorial decision in the credential: a weighting determines which competence a pass certifies and which it merely brushes. Publish one and you have committed to a view of the job that can be tested against practice and, if wrong, held against you. The Institute's position, labelled as the Institute's: **project controls, cost engineering and project finance are one discipline, and the boundary between them is where projects are lost**. The 40/40/20 split is that claim expressed as an examination.

— 2. Why finance is forty per cent

The usual objection is that controls professionals do not do accounting; accountants do. True, and beside the point. The controls professional does not record the entry — they originate the input that determines it. On a long-term contract accounted for over time by the cost-to-cost input method, the percentage complete driving recognised revenue is costs incurred against total expected costs. Total expected costs is the estimate at completion, and the estimate at completion is a controls output. That is how revenue arises in project-based businesses: the forecast defended in a monthly review lands, largely unaltered, in the profit the board reports.

The second reason is symmetrical. Without the finance half the controls half cannot be checked: actual cost is a ledger extract, and knowing whether it is complete means knowing whether the accruals were raised and the commitments captured. Cost variance computed on incomplete actuals is not a small error — it is a favourable one, the most dangerous kind.

— 3. Worked example — one forecast decision, two revenue numbers

Illustrative figures. One fixed-price contract accounted for over time under the cost-to-cost input method; currency USD, data date end of month 9. Money to the nearest whole unit, ratios to two decimal places, percentages to one — all computed from unrounded values.

Given. Contract price 12,000,000 · Budget at Completion (BAC) 10,000,000 · Planned Value (PV) 6,300,000 · Earned Value (EV) 6,000,000 · Actual Cost (AC) 5,700,000 · billed to date 6,400,000.

Step 1 — the controls position. Under budget, behind plan.

$CPI = EV \div AC = 6,000,000 \div 5,700,000 = 1.05$ $SPI = EV \div PV = 6,000,000 \div 6,300,000 = 0.95$ $CV = EV - AC = 6,000,000 - 5,700,000 = 300,000$ favourable $SV = EV - PV = 6,000,000 - 6,300,000 = (300,000)$ adverse

Step 2 — the index-based forecast, and what it does to revenue.

$EAC = BAC \div CPI = 10,000,000 \div 1.0526... = 9,500,000$ $VAC = BAC - EAC = 10,000,000 - 9,500,000 = 500,000$ favourable $Progress\ (cost-to-cost) = AC \div EAC = 5,700,000 \div 9,500,000 = 60.0\%$ $Revenue\ recognised\ to\ date = 60.0\% \times 12,000,000 = 7,200,000$ $Contract\ asset\ (unbilled) = 7,200,000 - 6,400,000 = 800,000$

$AC \div EAC$ came out at exactly the same 60.0 per cent as $EV \div BAC = 6,000,000 \div 10,000,000$. That is not a coincidence of these figures but an identity: where the estimate at completion is the index-based $BAC \div CPI$, then $AC \div EAC = AC \div (BAC \times AC \div EV) = EV \div BAC$, whatever the numbers. The accountant's percentage complete and the controls professional's are one calculation that two professions have been taught to name differently.

Step 3 — the forecast the practitioner actually defends. The index-based forecast assumes past cost performance continues. Suppose the control account managers' bottom-up estimate to complete puts the remaining work at 4,500,000, the favourable variance having come from early scope now finished.

$EAC = AC + ETC = 5,700,000 + 4,500,000 = 10,200,000$ $Progress = AC \div EAC = 5,700,000 \div 10,200,000 = 55.9\%$ $Revenue\ recognised\ to\ date = 55.9\% \times 12,000,000 = 6,705,882$ $Contract\ asset\ (unbilled) = 6,705,882 - 6,400,000 = 305,882$

The consequence. Substituting the bottom-up estimate for the index-based forecast moved recognised revenue from 7,200,000 to 6,705,882 — a reduction of 494,118, or $494,118 \div 12,000,000 = 4.1\%$ of the contract price. Nothing about the work changed. One judgement about the cost of the remaining scope changed the number the board reports.

Assumptions the answer depends on. A single performance obligation satisfied over time; no variable consideration or constraint in play; transaction price unchanged at 12,000,000; the two estimates at completion the only variable between the cases. Which method to use is itself a judgement, treated in [BPG-09 – Estimate at completion – choosing and defending a method](#).

— 4. Why project management is forty per cent and not sixty

Eight of the thirteen domains sit in the project management group — cost control, earned value, contracts, lifecycle, agile, scheduling, process cycles and risk — and on knowledge-area count it is

much the larger, thirty-five of sixty-one. It carries the same forty per cent, and this is the harder half of the argument.

The delivery group is weighted for what the professional must originate: the schedule logic, the measured progress, the committed cost, the quantified risk. The finance group is weighted for what they must stand behind, which requires comparable depth because the consequences are less visible and arrive later. A schedule error announces itself; a recognition error waits for an audit. Sixty per cent on delivery would reproduce a credential the market already has several of.

— 5. Why AI is twenty per cent, and not a chapter

Twenty per cent is deliberately uncomfortable in both directions.

Against a token chapter. AI now sits in the tooling of estimating, forecasting, document review, risk identification and reporting, and a professional who cannot judge an AI-produced forecast will either rubber-stamp it or refuse it — both failures of competence. AI proposes; the professional disposes, and disposing requires knowing what the model was given, what its output is sensitive to, what it cannot know and what a human must verify. A single chapter cannot carry a competence exercised weekly.

Against a larger share. Twenty per cent is also a ceiling, set there because AI in project controls is a governed application of the other twelve domains, not a replacement for them. Someone who prompts fluently but cannot compute an estimate at completion by hand has no basis on which to disagree with the machine.

The share is measured across the whole AI surface — every non-AI domain carries embedded coverage of governed AI use in its subject, and knowledge area 13.5 the systematic per-domain treatment. It will also age faster than the other two, as it should.

— 6. Why the weights attach to groups and not to domains

The Institute publishes three weights, not thirteen. Weighting each domain would imply a precision the evidence does not support: no defensible study has established that scheduling is worth 6.5 per cent of a controls professional's competence and process cycles 3.5 per cent. Group weights claim only what can be defended, and they protect candidates from a false optimisation — no domain is small enough to skip safely, and there is no per-domain passing requirement to game.

— 7. What would change the weighting

A position that cannot be falsified is not worth publishing. Three things would move this one.

A job-task analysis that contradicts it. A formal job-task analysis with practising professionals will validate the blueprint's sampling against the work the credential attests. If practitioners' actual task frequencies and criticality do not support a forty per cent finance group, the weight changes and the reason is published. Timing: [\[CONFIRM: date the job-task analysis reports, and whether it confirms the 40/40/20 group weights\]](#).

Evidence that the finance share is not discriminating. If item analysis after the first sittings shows the finance group failing to separate competent from not-yet-competent candidates, it is

testing recall rather than the judgement described in §2 — and the fix is item quality before it is weighting.

A material change in what AI does. If the judgement a professional must exercise over AI outputs broadens, the share rises; if verification becomes routine rather than skilled, it falls. Either way the change is published with its reason, and candidates are assessed only against the edition in force for their sitting.

— 8. How this goes wrong

As a study budget. The weights describe the paper, not your gaps; a planner weak on accounting should spend well over forty per cent of revision on Domains 1–4. **As a statement of workplace value.** Forty per cent examination weight is not forty per cent of a controls professional's week — sampling weights the knowledge a decision depends on, not the hours a task consumes, and the correct employer use is [PCB-06 – Using the Body of Knowledge: a guide for employers](#). **As a per-domain requirement.** There is no minimum score per domain and no published per-domain percentage; results carry a domain breakdown for diagnostic value, but the pass decision is made on the whole paper against one criterion-referenced standard. **As a prediction of where AI appears.** Governed-AI judgement sits inside items in any group, because that is where it sits at work.

— Related

- [PCB-01 – The Project Controls Body of Knowledge – executive summary](#) — the framework this weighting governs
- [PCB-02 – The thirteen domains at a glance](#) — which domains sit in which group
- [PCB-04 – What a project controls professional must know](#) — the propositions the weighting is designed to certify
- [EXB-02 – Domain weightings and the 40/40/20 rule](#) — how the group weights become a sampled examination form
- [EXB-06 – Job-task analysis: where the blueprint gets its authority](#) — the study that will test this weighting
- [BPG-09 – Estimate at completion – choosing and defending a method](#) — the judgement made in §3, treated in full

— Sources and standards

- PCL-AI Body of Knowledge, first authored draft ([docs/bok/](#)), August 2026: Domain 2 on revenue recognition and the cost-to-cost input method; Domain 3 on the cost baseline; Domain 6 on the earned value measures, indices and the estimate-at-completion family; Domain 7 on billing and the contract asset position; Domain 13 on governed AI use.
- The Style Spine ([docs/bok/00-style-spine.md](#)), August 2026: §1, the 40/40/20 weighting and the rule that the AI share is measured across the whole AI surface rather than one chapter.
- Examination Blueprint ([docs/downloads/examination-blueprint.md](#)), August 2026: §2, weights attach to groups not domains; §5, the job-task analysis and standard-setting commitments.

IFRS 15 is named as the standard governing revenue from contracts with customers, and the cost-to-cost input method is described in the Institute's own words. No standard text, table or clause is reproduced, and no edition is cited, because none was verified for this document. The worked example in §3 is illustrative and represents no real contract, organisation or project.

— Status and version

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